culture, and political discourse celebrating the so-called fall of the Wall. A large and still-growing body of historical literature and cultural works references the Berlin Wall in an attempt to make sense of America's role in the Cold War, from its early years through its demise to its afterlife today.

Such narratives of the Berlin Wall within sites of public interpretation and expression often work through the landmarks of presidential visits and military operations, treating cultural expressions as necessary only for background soundtracks and illustrations or as endearing oddities to animate a teleological story from rise to fall. President Kennedy's refrains of symbolic citizenship in 1963 ("Ich Bin ein Berliner" and "Let them come to Berlin") and President Reagan's bold plea in 1987 ("Mr. Gorbachev, tear down this wall") reverberate as dramatic moments of American rhetoric at two opposing ends of this timeline, without much attention to what narratives they obscure and in what ways they are extensively mythologized, parodied, critiqued, and remixed. In other words, they obscure how the lessons from the dismantled Berlin Wall inform and haunt American public discourse on our own walls.

The American fascination with the Wall did not fade after the initial shock of construction in 1961 or during the decades of simmering coexistence or with the dismantling of the Wall in 1989. In fact, over time, the Berlin Wall has become even more embedded within the landscape and discourses of U.S. geopolitics. Hundreds of cultural references express intrigue in Berlin's divided status. Rarer are works that consider the way the story of the Wall has been incorporated into our U.S. national narrative and for what purposes. For example, a broken piece of the former Berlin Wall from the collection of the Smithsonian Institution in Washington, D.C., was included in *The Smithsonian's History of America in 101 Objects* with an annotation qualifying it only by its existence as a fragment ("This one has special meaning precisely because it is broken!"), rather than as an outlier in this quintessential collection of "Americana."[17] Much of our public history related to the Berlin Wall often recounts America's relationship to the Wall in similar fashion, across dozens of prominent sites, supplemented by fields of documentary film and television, museum and library exhibitions, commercials and advertisements, online wikis and memes, and other references to the Wall across cultural formats, often portraying the Wall as a self-apparent symbol of progress without room for critical